



[Course](#) > [4. Reporting your findings](#) > [4.2 Structuring your report](#) > Structuring your chapters

Structuring your chapters

🔖 Bookmark this page

Once you have chosen how to divide your research into chapters, you need to determine the internal structure of each chapter. A page or two filled with uninterrupted text would be very hard to read.

The structure of a chapter is basically a smaller version of the structure of the entire report:

- An informative chapter title,
- A chapter introduction: one or several paragraphs outlining the purpose and content of this chapter,
- The main body of the chapter, possibly divided into several sections,
- A chapter conclusion, summarizing the results that have been found in this chapter.

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

How can you help the reader with little time when designing your core chapters?

Multiple answers are correct.

☒ Use an informative chapter title;

☒ Use informative section titles;

☒ Start the chapter with a short chapter introduction;

☒ Use numbered sections, as numbers make information easier to find;

☒ Give a conclusion or summary at the end of each chapter.



Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



[Submit](#)

You have used 4 of 10 attempts

A chapter introduction

After the informative chapter title has told your readers what to expect, the chapter introduction can provide more details. It complements the chapter title and should be clearly linked to it. In one or maybe several paragraphs, you explain the purpose of the chapter and outline its structure. Mention section numbers explicitly here, to allow your readers to find relevant information quickly.

If possible, use your chapter introduction to link the chapter to the preceding work. You can also provide some background information here, to provide some context to the work done in the chapter.

The exercises below provide several examples of chapter introductions, to help you get a feeling for what makes them more (or less) useful to a reader.

Exercise B

1/1 point (graded)

Please read the following chapter introduction:

Chapter 2: Literature review

Geothermal energy is a promising new energy resource. It is cost-effective, reliable, sustainable and environmentally friendly. Historically its application has remained limited to areas close to tectonic plate boundaries. With recent technological developments, geothermal energy could potentially be exploited on a larger scale. It is important to map the development of geothermal energy in order to determine possible future success factors.

Based on text retrieved from Wikipedia: *Geothermal energy*. Retrieved 13-4-2017 from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geothermal_energy. Edited and adapted for this question.

Which of the following statements is true about this chapter introduction?

Multiple answers can be correct.

☐ The chapter title is informative;

☐ The purpose of the chapter is clearly stated;

☐ The necessary background information is provided;

Pursue a verified certificate

[Upgrade Now \(\\$49\)](#)



**Answer**

Correct:

A chapter introduction needs to prepare the reader for the chapter. This means a chapter introduction should fulfil a few criteria: (a) it should clearly state the purpose of the chapter, (b) the chapter structure should be announced including section numbers, and (c) the chapter title and chapter introduction should be clearly linked to show coherence. The chapter introduction above does not contain any of these required elements. Preferably, the chapter introduction also shows the connection of the current chapter with the previous chapter. This means it might contain some background information, but it is not mandatory.

Submit

You have used 9 of 10 attempts

Exercise C

1/1 point (graded)

Please read the following chapter introduction:

Chapter 2: Literature review

The introduction chapter showed that geothermal energy is a promising new energy resource. Various sources suggest that it is cost-effective, reliable, sustainable and environmentally friendly. However, it has not yet been used on a large scale. First, section 2.1 briefly explores the history of geothermal energy by discussing possibilities and limitations of its very first applications. After that, section 2.2 provides an overview of the most promising recent technological developments in geothermal energy. Finally, based on the historical overview and the recent developments, section 2.3 aims to determine possible success factors for future widespread application of geothermal energy.

Based on text retrieved from Wikipedia: *Geothermal energy*. Retrieved 13-4-2017 from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geothermal_energy. Edited and adapted for this question.

Which of the following statements is true about this chapter introduction?

Multiple answers can be correct.

☐ It does not contain an overview of the chapter's structure;☒ It is linked to the previous chapter;☒ It does not contain a clear purpose of the chapter;☐ The chapter title is informative and clearly linked to the introduction.**Pursue a verified certificate****Upgrade Now (\$49)**

Correct:

The chapter introduction above contains a link to the previous chapter in the first sentence. It also sets out what information the reader can expect in the various sections, including section numbers and a clear link between different sections using signposts ("First...", "After that...", "Based on..."). However, a clear chapter purpose is missing. Furthermore, the chapter title is not informative and still not reflected in the chapter introduction; if the information in the chapter is collected by means of a literature review, it should be mentioned in the chapter introduction.

Submit

You have used 1 of 10 attempts

Exercise D

1/1 point (graded)

Please read the chapter introduction above again.

Which of the following formulations of the chapter's purpose would be most informative?

- ☐ This chapter provides an overview of geothermal energy developments;
- ☐ This chapter contains a literature review of geothermal energy applications;
- ☐ The purpose of this chapter is to show the historical development of geothermal energy, recent technological developments and possible future applications;
- ☒ This chapter aims to determine possible success factors for the application of geothermal energy on a large scale. ✓

Answer

Correct:

The purpose statement "This chapter aims to determine possible success factors for the application of geothermal energy on a large scale" would be most informative here, as it focuses most specifically on the desired outcome of the chapter. The discussion of historical applications in section 2.1 and the more recent technological developments in section 2.2 seem to be used to draw conclusions about success factors in section 2.3. The information in 2.1 and 2.2 is supportive; it is necessary to achieve the aim for which the results are presented in 2.3. The first and second answers are too generic and abstract, whereas the third answer is merely an repetition of the chapter's structure.

Submit

You have used 2 of 3 attempts

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



Exercise E

1/1 point (graded)

Please read the chapter introduction above again.

Which of the following chapter titles would be most informative?

☒ Success factors for large-scale application of geothermal energy; ✓

☐ Literature review: geothermal energy applications;

☐ History and recent developments of geo-thermal energy;

☐ The current title is fine as it is.

Answer

Correct:

The first title is closest to what seems to be the chapter's purpose. The chapter works towards conclusions about success factors in the final section. The term 'literature review' is not mentioned in the chapter introduction and gives the reader no information. In case it is important to emphasize the method used (literature review), that should be included in the chapter introduction. Even then, the reader wants to know the subject of the reviewed literature.

Submit

You have used 3 of 3 attempts

✓ Correct (1/1 point)

Exercise F

1/1 point (graded)

The chapter introduction below lacks an explicit purpose. The chapter's purpose could be formulated as follows: "This chapter aims to determine possible success factors for the application of geothermal energy on a large scale". Four possible positions to include the chapter's purpose are indicated.

Chapter 2: Success factors for large-scale application of geothermal energy

[1] The introduction chapter showed that geothermal energy is a promising new energy resource. Various sources suggest that it is cost-effective, reliable, sustainable and environmentally friendly. **[2]** However, it has not yet been used on a large scale. **[3]** First, section 2.1 briefly

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



technological developments in geothermal energy. Based on the historical overview and the recent developments, section 2.3 aims to determine possible success factors for future widespread application of geothermal energy. [4]

Based on text retrieved from Wikipedia: *Geothermal energy*. Retrieved 13-4-2017 from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geothermal_energy. Edited and adapted for this question.

Which of the four positions in the chapter introduction is most appropriate to include the chapter's purpose?

☐ Position 1;

☐ Position 2;

☒ Position 3; ✓

☐ Position 4.

Answer

Correct:

When reading the text, it seems most apt to place the chapter introduction in position 3. This way, the reader understands the context for the purpose (promising, but not yet widely used) and the structure of the chapter can be interpreted in the light of the purpose.

Submit

You have used 1 of 3 attempts

Writing your own chapter introductions

Based on the information about chapter introductions and the feedback on the questions, you can start writing your own chapter introductions. Ask yourself the following questions:

- Is the link with the previous chapter(s) clear?
- Does the chapter introduction contain a clear purpose statement?
- Does the purpose statement accurately reflect the content of the chapter?
- Does the chapter introduction contain a structure overview, including section numbers and clear connections between the sections?

The main body of a chapter

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)



you should feel free to include additional sections, or split up your modelling cycle in a different way. The goal of dividing a chapter into sections, is to clarify its structure and break it up into clearly identified components.

When structuring a chapter, you can ask yourself the following questions:

- Does each section have a clear, single purpose?
- Does each section have an informative title?
- Does each section have a correct number?
- Is the structure of this chapter correctly outlined in the chapter introduction, including section numbers?

Note: If your chapter contains sections, it should have at least two of them. One section on its own will not clarify the structure of your chapter.

A chapter conclusion

Finally, your chapter should end with a chapter conclusion. Here, you summarize the work done in this chapter and draw conclusions when appropriate. All statements made in this chapter conclusion should be supported by the work done in the main body of the chapter.

Together, the chapter introduction and chapter conclusion should give a good overview of the chapter to a reader with no interest in details or calculations.

We have now covered division into chapters, and further division into sections. The next page discusses how to divide the text of a section into paragraphs.

© All Rights Reserved



 English ▼

Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)





Pursue a verified certificate

Upgrade Now (\$49)

